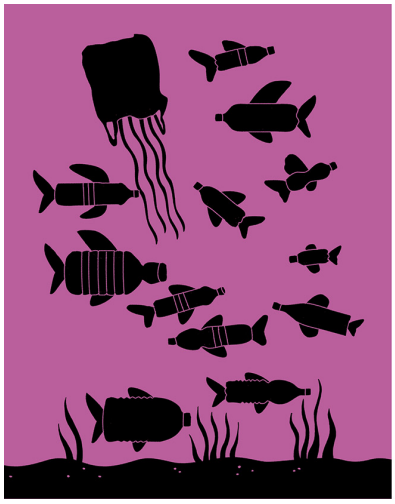


OUR OCEANS ARE TURNING INTO A PLASTIC SOUP

A PLASTIC WASTELAND

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Charles J. Moore (1947–)

BEFORE

1970s Scientists begin to research plastic litter at sea after reports in the journal *Science* describe large numbers of plastic pellets in the North Atlantic.

1984 The first International Marine Debris Conference, held in Hawaii, raises awareness of the growing problem of litter in the oceans.

AFTER

2016 The documentary *A Plastic Ocean*, directed by Australian journalist Craig Leeson, highlights the global effects of plastic pollution.

2018 The Earth Day Network, an organization committed to spreading the environmental movement worldwide, makes End Plastic Pollution the theme of Earth Day, on April 22, 2018.

When plastics were first mass produced in the early 20th century, the world marveled at the versatility and durability of a material that could be molded into any shape, used, and then thrown away. The problem with plastic, however, is that most of it never goes away. Across the world, we produce